



NEETA SATAM FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Looking for Adventure on America’s ‘Mother Road’
Bikers from Europe on Route 66 in Stanton, Mo. The road has experienced an influx of foreign visitors. Sunday Business, Page 4.

In Ukraine, Fraud Is Rewarded With More Weapons Contracts

This article is by **Andrew E. Kraemer**, **Bianca Pallaro** and **Evelina Riabenko**.

KYIV, Ukraine — As Russian soldiers attacked trench lines in eastern Ukraine in 2024, Ukrainian artillery crews opened fire. But the rounds, instead of exploding near the advancing troops, flopped out of launch tubes or landed with quiet thumps, kicking up puffs of dust.

A Ukrainian arms factory, it turned out, had supplied the military with thousands of defective mortar rounds. A burly weapons factory boss, Leonid Shyman, would eventually be arrested and

charged in one of the war’s most public examples of defense-industry fraud.

But even as the officials noticed that weapons being received were faulty, government audits obtained by The New York Times show, Ukraine’s Defense Procurement Agency continued to award Mr. Shyman’s factory new contracts.

The case reflects a persistent phenomenon of the war in Ukraine. Seven of Ukraine’s top 10 military contractors won new business despite open criminal investigations for fraud, failures to deliver on earlier deals, or the arrest of chief executives for corruption, according to the government

Secret Military Audits Find Flawed System Enriches Suppliers

audits obtained by The Times, court records and Ukrainian news accounts.

Mr. Shyman, for example, had been the subject of multiple investigations by anti-corruption agencies, including for embezzlement and fraud, when he won that first mortar contract. The government awarded the \$280 million deal while he was out on bail.

Confidential reviews by the

State Audit Service and an internal Ministry of Defense auditing department reveal a military procurement system riddled with mismanagement. Warning signs go unheeded, the records show, and there are seldom consequences for overcharging or failing to deliver.

Companies won contracts without demonstrating that they could supply the weapons, or without licenses to deliver them. Auditors identified 18 companies that signed deals despite defaulting on previous agreements. Six of those failed to fulfill a single contract.

Military contractors around the globe, including the world’s rich-

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Mayor Enlists Friendly Army Of Influencers

By **SALLY GOLDENBERG** and **EMMA GOLDBERG**

On the morning of March 25, a flood of posts that struck a remarkably similar tone began popping up on scattered social media sites.

Mayor Zohran Mamdani had just decided to cancel a \$9 million contract that New York City had with the consulting giant McKinsey, and gushing praise came pouring in from commentators, operatives on the left and even some comedians.

Alex Jacquez, who works at a progressive think tank, posted on X: “Really exciting that NYC is generating operational efficiencies by in-sourcing needlessly outsourced public services and functions, building city capacity. More of this!”

Akilah Hughes, a comedian with more than 200,000 followers on X, reposted a comment suggesting that Mr. Mamdani was an improvement over his predecessor, Eric Adams, who “paid McKinsey \$1.6 million to research trash cans.”

Matt Stoller, a political commentator with more than 160,000 followers on X, wrote effusively that the mayor “just cut a \$9 million contract that McKinsey has with NYC. And then brags about it publicly. More please.”

Some of the online adulation,

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NEPAL ARMY, VIA REUTERS

Alive After 10 Days Underground
A Chinese hydropower worker was one of two people rescued after flooding in Nepal. Page 10.

Plan Would Shift Some Aid Meant for Working Parents to Stay-at-Home Spouses

By **CORAL DAVENPORT**

WASHINGTON — The Trump administration is moving to allow married couples with a stay-at-home spouse to collect child care subsidies, a policy championed by Vice President JD Vance, using funds from a federal program intended to assist working parents, according to people familiar with

the discussions.

The change would create the only federal subsidy to pay parents to stay home and raise their children, one of the most significant efforts to date by the Trump administration to harness federal funds to promote a traditional view of families.

To do so, officials are seeking to use a Health and Human Services

A Vance Priority to Push Traditional Families

Department fund that was created in the 1990s to help low-income and working-class parents afford child care so they could work or go to school.

How U.S. Widened Effort Against Covid Scientists

As Fauci Was Put Under Public Scrutiny, More Experts Were Quietly Targeted

By **BENJAMIN MUELLER** and **GLENN THRUSH**

In early 2025, Dan Bongino, the fiery No. 2 official at the F.B.I., summoned dozens of agents to the bureau’s Washington headquarters.

Mr. Bongino, a conservative media personality recently elevated to the deputy’s role, demanded to know why a yearslong inquiry into the origins of the Covid-19 pandemic had stalled — and why investigators had not more forcefully scrutinized the role of government scientists, current and former officials said.

At one point, he squared off against an official who questioned the theory that he and many supporters of President Trump had long promoted: that the virus had not merely leaked from a Chinese lab, but that American researchers, among them Dr. Anthony S. Fauci, had orchestrated a conspiracy to cover up that fact.

The meeting became so heated that Mr. Bongino ultimately asked the official to leave the room, an attendee said.

Mr. Bongino, who stepped down from the F.B.I. in January to return to podcasting, and other officials helped set in motion a sprawling and aggressive investigative effort that has outlasted his tenure, The New York Times has learned.

As part of that effort, F.B.I. agents and federal prosecutors have sought evidence related to at least eight scientists, among them a Nobel laureate and influential former government researchers like Dr. Fauci.

Investigators have demanded phone, email, grant and payment records, as well as grand jury testimony by scientists.

This account of the investigations is drawn from interviews with six current and former officials familiar with them, who asked not to be identified because they were not authorized to speak publicly, as well as documents reviewed by The Times.

It is not clear what evidence those inquiries have produced or what their status is. Dr. Fauci, once the government’s chief infectious disease scientist, received a pre-emptive pardon last year from former President Joseph R. Biden Jr. that protects him from federal prosecution for official actions from 2014 to 2025.

The inquiries were underway well before Republican lawmakers last month asked the Department of Justice to investigate Dr. Fauci’s refusal to answer questions before a Senate panel. They have continued playing out behind the scenes as those lawmakers



From left, Dan Bongino, the former deputy F.B.I. director, and Dr. Anthony S. Fauci.

ers released documents that have bruised Dr. Fauci’s reputation.

Many scientists see the federal government’s investigative effort as an attempt to punish political enemies and deflect blame from the first Trump administration for the catastrophic effects of the pandemic.

While the origins of the coronavirus have not definitively been established, these researchers point to the fact that the inquiries have failed to produce any clear evidence that Dr. Fauci or other American scientists covered up knowledge of a lab leak, or funded or collaborated on research that led to one.

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LEAK HUNT The Pentagon gave polygraph tests to about 50 members of the Joint Staff. PAGE 20

Kenyans Wrote College Essays For Americans. Then Came A.I.

By **ADAM SATARIANO** and **PAUL MOZUR**

NAIROBI, Kenya — Teresios Bundi once symbolized the strange, life-changing opportunities the internet provided.

Hailing from a farming village in Kenya, Mr. Bundi moved to the capital, Nairobi, in 2011 to be the first in his family to attend university. There, a friend suggested he try a new online job: writing essays for cheating overseas college students.

His first assignment was a two-page essay on the health benefits of the Garcinia cambogia. It was a fruit he had never heard of, and an essay written for a student he didn’t know anything about. He earned \$7 for three hours of work.

“That was a lifeline for me, I needed the money,” Mr. Bundi, now 34, said in an interview in Nairobi. He added: “I could not sleep that night. I was ready to

burn the midnight oil.”

Mr. Bundi estimates he wrote more than 2,500 essays over the next 12 years, sometimes three a day.

Mr. Bundi didn’t know it then, but he was in the boom era of internet gig work. Newly wired to the global internet and hungry for jobs, well-educated youths from places like Kenya, the Philippines and India found opportunities in the crevices of the digital economy. They could make money online doing unglamorous tasks that others further up the economic ladder did not want to do.

Then A.I. arrived, and the good times ended.

In 2022, OpenAI released ChatGPT. At colleges worldwide, students made a simple calculation that has become more prosleep that night. I was ready to

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INTERNATIONAL 4-15

Trump’s Name, Not His Style

A village of small prefab homes on the Israeli-controlled Golan Heights is named for the U.S. president but lacks the gilded Trump aesthetic. PAGE 4

Deploying Chemical Weapons

Leaked documents bolster claims that Sudan’s military developed and used toxic bombs in the civil war. PAGE 12

NATIONAL 16-24

Silent Sentinels of City Life

The bollard is a symbol of the hardened landscape of the post-9/11 city. It is also used as street furniture. PAGE 18



ARTS & LEISURE

Connecting Through Curiosity

In concert halls or small gatherings, the cellist Yo-Yo Ma learns a lot by asking people questions. Bringing people together is what drives him. PAGE 4

SUNDAY OPINION

Ruxandra Teslo

PAGE 6

SUNDAY STYLES

The Queen of Many Courts

By wearing a wide-ranging collection created by multiple designers, Naomi Osaka has done much to change the game of tennis fashion this year. PAGE 8

Gloria Steinem’s Glamour

Her glasses, hairdo, bell bottoms and hip-slung belts were a part of a larger message and a bigger cause. PAGE 3

REAL ESTATE

Learning to Live With Sharks

As great whites have moved into Massachusetts waters, Cape Cod has changed to make room for them. PAGE 6



SPECIAL SECTION

Urban Explorations

Comprehensive guides to eight major tourist cities, including Copenhagen, above, geared to a first-time visitor.

SUNDAY BUSINESS

More Housing? Not This Year.

A plan by billionaires to build a city, with thousands of homes, hit a legislative setback. “It’s just incredibly hard to do large projects in California.” PAGE 1

METROPOLITAN

The City’s Past Is Still Visible

Traces of New York’s layered histories can be found scattered throughout a contemporary urban landscape. You just need to look. PAGE 4

